

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Data Analytics and Business Intelligence English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For data analysts, BI developers, analytics engineers, data scientists, reporting teams, business analysts, and data-driven managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

- 01 Agreeing on a metric
- 02 Dashboard refresh failure
- 03 Duplicate records
- 04 Clarifying a request
- 05 Association and causation
- 06 Experiment imbalance
- 07 Data access request
- 08 An executive readout

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Agreeing on a metric

An analyst and stakeholder define active customers.

Roles: BI analyst / Sales operations manager

BI analyst: Does active customer mean a signed contract or a purchase in the reporting period?

Sales operations manager: For this dashboard, at least one completed purchase in the last 90 days.

BI analyst: Should canceled and fully refunded orders count?

Sales operations manager: No. Let's write those exclusions into the definition.

BI analyst: I'll document the time zone, source tables, and refresh schedule too.

Sales operations manager: Send the definition for review before building the chart so other teams can use the same measure.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Does active customer mean a signed contract or a purchase in the reporting period?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Dashboard refresh failure

A stakeholder reports stale dashboard figures.

Roles: Business stakeholder / Data engineer

Business stakeholder: The dashboard hasn't changed since yesterday. Have sales stopped?

Data engineer: No conclusion about sales follows from that. The scheduled data load failed overnight.

Business stakeholder: Can you show users the last successful refresh time?

Data engineer: Yes. I'll mark the dashboard as stale and investigate the failed job.

Business stakeholder: I'll pause this morning's performance comparison until the data are current.

Data engineer: I'll confirm the repaired load and completeness checks before telling you the dashboard is ready.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The dashboard hasn't changed since yesterday. Have sales stopped?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Duplicate records

An analyst finds a sudden increase after a data join.

Roles: Data analyst / Analytics engineer

Data analyst: Revenue doubles after I join orders to shipments. The source order total hasn't changed.

Analytics engineer: Is the join one-to-many? An order can have several shipments.

Data analyst: Yes. I'm repeating the order amount for each shipment row.

Analytics engineer: Aggregate at the intended grain before comparing, and check the join keys.

Data analyst: I'll reconcile distinct orders and revenue to the source totals.

Analytics engineer: Document the grain in the model so future reports don't repeat the same error.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Is the join one-to-many? An order can have several shipments." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Clarifying a request

A manager asks for every available customer field.

Roles: Analytics lead / Marketing manager

Analytics lead: What decision will the customer extract support?

Marketing manager: We want to understand which onboarding step has the highest drop-off.

Analytics lead: Then we may need event counts by step rather than a broad personal-data export.

Marketing manager: Agreed. Could we also compare acquisition channels?

Analytics lead: Yes, subject to data availability and access rules. I'll propose the smallest useful dataset.

Marketing manager: I'll confirm the decision and reporting period so we can review whether the analysis answers the question.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What decision will the customer extract support?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Association and causation

A team reviews a regional sales comparison.

Roles: Analyst / Regional manager

Analyst: Regions using the new script sold more, but the comparison is observational.

Regional manager: Can we say the script caused the increase?

Analyst: Not from this alone. Those regions also had different staffing and customer mixes.

Regional manager: What would strengthen the evidence?

Analyst: A suitable experimental or carefully justified comparison design, with its limitations explicit.

Regional manager: For now, describe the association accurately and recommend how to evaluate the script more rigorously.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can we say the script caused the increase?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Experiment imbalance

An analyst checks an experiment before interpreting results.

Roles: Experiment analyst / Product lead

Experiment analyst: The allocation ratio differs sharply from the planned split. We need to investigate that first.

Product lead: Could the favorable result still be real?

Experiment analyst: Possibly, but assignment or logging problems could bias it. Significance doesn't fix a broken design.

Product lead: I'll keep the rollout decision pending.

Experiment analyst: I'll review eligibility, assignment, and event completeness with engineering.

Product lead: Bring the validity findings alongside the outcome metrics, so the decision reflects the quality of the evidence.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Could the favorable result still be real?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Data access request

A department requests access to a restricted dataset.

Roles: Department analyst / Data steward

Department analyst: I need the employee-level dataset for a turnover report. What access is appropriate?

Data steward: Start with the purpose and required fields. An aggregated dataset may meet the need.

Department analyst: I only need trends by department and tenure band.

Data steward: Then let's assess that output and any small-group disclosure concerns under our policy.

Department analyst: I'll submit the request with the audience and retention period.

Data steward: I'll route it for the required approval and confirm the permitted dataset and handling conditions.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "I need the employee-level dataset for a turnover report. What access is appropriate?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

An executive readout

An analyst prepares a concise performance explanation.

Roles: Senior analyst / Finance director

Senior analyst: Orders fell eight percent, while revenue fell three percent. Higher average order value offset part of the volume decline.

Finance director: Is that price or product mix?

Senior analyst: The current bridge suggests mix, but I still need to reconcile discount effects.

Finance director: Lead with the confirmed movement, then identify that open question.

Senior analyst: I'll include the comparison period, reconciliation status, and the largest contributing categories.

Finance director: Good. Recommend the next analysis without presenting an unverified driver as a settled explanation.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Is that price or product mix?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Metric Definitions and Business Questions

SHARED CASE

Two teams report different active-user totals. One counts logins; the other counts completed transactions.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What action qualifies a user as active, and over what period? The two totals use different definitions. Let's agree on the business question and label each measure clearly.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Data Quality and Trust

SHARED CASE

A dashboard refreshed today, but one source table contains data only through Monday. A manager assumes all figures are current.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The dashboard refreshed today, but that table is current only through Monday. I'll show the source's data cutoff separately from the dashboard refresh time.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Dashboards and Executive Reporting

SHARED CASE

A KPI card shows a monthly total without its target, comparison period, or definition. The reader cannot interpret whether the result is favorable.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The total needs context. I'll add the definition, reporting period, and relevant comparison so the reader can understand what changed and whether action is needed.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Causation, Correlation, and Caveats

SHARED CASE

Customers who attend training renew more often. Attendance was voluntary, and the groups may differ in motivation.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Training attendance is associated with renewal in this dataset. That does not establish causation; the groups may differ in other ways. I'll state the finding with that limitation.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

SQL, Models, and Transformation Logic

SHARED CASE

A report joins order rows to several payment rows per order. Revenue appears larger after the join.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What does one row represent in each table? The join may repeat order values when there are multiple payments. Let's check the grain and aggregation before interpreting the total.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Experiment Readouts and Statistical Thinking

SHARED CASE

An experiment estimates a positive effect, but the interval includes values close to no change. The slide presents only the point estimate.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll show the estimated effect and its uncertainty together. The point estimate alone hides the range of values compatible with the analysis and can make the result sound more certain than it is.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Data Governance and Privacy

SHARED CASE

An analyst wants customer-level data but has not specified which fields are needed or how long they will be retained.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you define the analysis purpose, necessary fields, and retention period? That will let the appropriate team review access and privacy requirements before the data is shared.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Insight Storytelling and Recommendations

SHARED CASE

A report lists ten findings but no recommended action. The audience has five minutes to decide whether to investigate a service issue.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll lead with the finding relevant to that decision, explain its limitation, and recommend a specific investigation. The other findings can support the discussion without obscuring the request.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.